

FOREWORD

There are two questions that I am often asked when people learn that I am a tea sommelier: first, what is a tea sommelier? and second, how did I become so interested in tea?

I like to answer the second question first. While it might imply that there was an exact moment in time when I abandoned the tea bags and elected to follow the “true path of tea,” this was not the case. Rather, there was a gradual introduction to loose-leaf tea that slowly and steadily changed my perspective. Through study, experience, travelling to places where tea originated, and learning from industry masters, I found myself immersed in the world of tea.

The nuances of other tea cultures were revealed layer by layer, as I came to understand their unique styles of tea and their traditions of preparation and serving. While formalities are to be respected with ceremonies and traditions, the modern approach to tea encourages fresh experiences such as tea mixology, cold infusions, lattés, and much more. I enjoy discovering new ways to experience tea, sometimes fusing the practices of one culture with those of another.

The first question still hangs in the air, and I hope that after answering the “how,” the “what” begins to make sense. The tea sommelier has the challenging task of convincing tea drinkers that there is much more to tea than a mug and a tea bag. Beyond the bag there is mystery, history, travel, industry, culture, and ceremony: a whole new world to explore.

I want *The Tea Book* to be your entry into this vast and enticing universe. Whether you are new to loose leaves or know your oolong from your Pu’er, you will find something to interest you. I hope you will develop your own thirst for tea, and the adventures it will provide.

Linda Gaylard